

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

6 arrested in South Shore raid could be released

Venezuelans among hundreds who may get bond amid allegations about agents

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

At least six Venezuelan nationals arrested in a controversial immigration raid on a South Shore apartment building in September are among hundreds who could soon be released on bond amid allegations that Operation Midway Blitz agents repeatedly violated a consent decree limiting warrantless arrests.

The immigrants from the Sept. 30 raid at 7500 S. South Shore Drive appeared on a list released Friday of some 614 arrestees identified in an ongoing lawsuit alleging the Department of Homeland

Security ignored the terms of the 2022 in-court settlement that puts a higher bar on making arrests without a prior warrant or probable cause.

All six people from the South Shore raid who are on the list were confirmed to the Tribune by plaintiffs' attorneys. They are all still in custody in the U.S. and were ranked in the "low" safety risk category, even by the government's notably low standard.

The South Shore operation had been billed as an attempt to arrest gang members in the country illegally. But a low risk category indicates there is not only a lack of any serious criminal history in their

background, but also no identifiable ties to gangs or other factors that would trigger mandatory detention.

The list was turned over by order of U.S. District Judge Jeffrey Cummings, who said he will grant a \$1,500 bond to anyone who is still in custody in the U.S. and who is not confirmed by the government to be a safety risk or subject to a prior removal order.

Attorneys with the Department of Justice told Cummings on Friday they were not seeking to keep anyone marked "low" in custody, meaning the six are likely to be released on bond sometime this week, unless Cummings or the 7th U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals grants the government a stay on

Turn to Released, Page 4



Following a recent large-scale immigration raid, the building at 7500 S. South Shore Drive has lost many of its tenants. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

IN NATION & WORLD

- U.S. immigration agents arrested more than 130 people in a weekend sweep through Charlotte, North Carolina.
- The Department of Homeland Security has diverted thousands of federal agents from normal duties to focus on arresting immigrants living in the country illegally, undermining a range of law enforcement operations.
- Naturalized citizens now fear the push to drastically increase deportations and a shift in who can claim America as home.

Mayor's head tax defeated in vote



Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson speaks at City Hall after his proposed head tax was voted down in a City Council committee meeting Monday. Ald. Jason Ervin, 28th, is at left. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

"Working-class Chicagoans can simply just not afford a property tax increase. Let me be clear: There are not any magic third options in cuts to core services and layoffs and revenue. Anyone who wants to pretend otherwise is being disingenuous." — Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson

Johnson challenges aldermen to produce better spending plan

By Alice Yin, Jake Sheridan
and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Aldermen voted down Mayor Brandon Johnson's 2026 budget in a Monday committee, a remarkably rebellious display against the freshman mayor who has been struggling to shore up support for his controversial head tax.

But to hear Johnson tell it, the fight over the per-employee tax on Chicago's bigger companies is far from over.

After the rancorous Finance Committee meeting adjourned, he challenged aldermen to come up with a better spending plan, but promised to veto any budget that includes a property tax increase, a grocery tax or a garbage fee hike. That means the City Council would need 34 out of 50 votes to override him.

"Working-class Chicagoans can simply just not afford a property tax increase," the mayor told reporters. "Let me be clear: There are not any magic third options in cuts to core services and layoffs and revenue. Anyone who wants to pretend otherwise is being disingenuous."

And even after its defeat Monday, Johnson doubled down on his backing of the head tax as a way to make corporations pay their fair share, setting up a difficult stretch run as he and aldermen try to find common ground on a balanced budget before the end of the year. "The corporate tax is in this budget. It will stay

Turn to Tax, Page 4

Pritzker deposits own money into campaign fund

Gov. JB Pritzker has contributed \$25.5 million from his vast personal fortune into his campaign fund with four months to go until Illinois' March 17 primary elections and a year before voters will decide whether to give him a third term. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Pediatric health care facility makes progress in Austin

Austin community residents, civic leaders and developers celebrated Monday at a beam-raising event for the Austin HOPE Center, a \$22 million development that will provide pediatric health care services hard to find on Chicago's West Side. **Business**

Reversal precedes Epstein files House vote



A billboard highlights a comment by Jeffrey Epstein about President Donald Trump on Monday in New York. **ADAM GRAY/GETTY**

Facing party rebuke, president urges GOP to endorse release

By Stephen Groves,
Matt Brown and
Joey Cappelletti
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The House is heading toward an expected vote Tuesday on a bill to force the Justice Department to release the case files it has collected on the late financier Jeffrey Epstein, pushing past a monthslong effort by President Donald Trump and Republican leaders to stymie the effort.

The push for more disclosure in the years-old sex trafficking investigation into Epstein has come roaring back since the House returned to Washington after a nearly two-month absence

during the government shutdown. As lawmakers returned last week, they were greeted by new details from a tranche of Epstein's emails, including claims that Trump had "spent hours" at Epstein's house with a sex trafficking victim and that he "knew about the girls."

As it became apparent that the bill will pass the House, most likely with significant support from Republican lawmakers, Trump and House Speaker Mike Johnson changed their approach from outright opposition.

In a social media post Sunday, Trump urged House Republicans to back a measure that would compel the Justice Department to release the Epstein files, a reversal after his campaign to tamp down GOP dissent and halt the vote.

Trump said Republicans should vote to release files related to the

Turn to Epstein, Page 4

TODAY'S
WEATHER



High 44 Low 41

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
178th year No. 322 © Chicago Tribune

